

ANSWERS

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we find the people
in the know

Why did the city close down Maine Street from Fourth to 10th streets for one to two weeks instead of doing the work incrementally, allowing for more north-south streets to be open? Right now, drivers either have to go north on Fourth Street, south on Fifth Street or either direction on 12th Street.

The decision to fully close the streets for a total of three days for milling and for one day of resurfacing, instead of doing that work incrementally, was based on the goal of getting the work completed in the quickest, most cost-effective, productive and safest manner, city engineer Jeff Steinkamp said. Doing the milling and resurfacing work on an incremental block-by-block basis would have prolonged the work congestion by at least two times and would not have produced the pavement quality required. Allowing traffic in the work zone would have been unsafe for both the construction workers and the driving motorists, he said. The majority of the work done the past two weeks, such as the placement of leveling binder and utility adjustment of man-holes and water valves, was done on a block-by-block basis. “The city has been sensitive to the inconveniences caused by this recent construction work and greatly appreciates everyone’s patience and understanding as this \$2 million infrastructure improvement project in the uptown corridor draws to completion,” Steinkamp said.

If I smell gas in my house, who do I call to get it checked out?

If it’s a strong smell, get out of the house immediately and contact Ameren CIPS. The company offers free service to check for gas leaks. Call toll-free (888) 789-2477. “If it’s a real strong smell, any electrical spark could ignite leaking gas,” Ameren Illinois Utilities spokesman Leigh Morris said. “A gas leak should never be ignored.”

Who is responsible for trimming the bushes and trees back from the west side of 39th Street between Columbus Road and Westbury Drive? And why is there a no-parking sign in this area?

City engineer Jeff Steinkamp says if the bushes and trees are located on city right of way, then the city is responsible for trimming them. If they are located on private property, then the landowner is responsible. The city is allowed by ordinance to “have the right to prune or trim any tree or shrub on private property when it impedes, obstructs or interferes with traffic or travel or obstructs the visibility of any intersection traffic-control device or sign.” Steinkamp says the no-parking sign is authorized by city ordinance, which does not allow parking on either side of North 39th Street from Columbus Road to the entrance to Wavering Park. “I would assume that the parking restriction was implemented due to the narrowness of the roadway, the amount of vehicle traffic and that no residents live on this section of street,” Steinkamp said.

Curious about anything going on in your community? Submit e-mail questions to answers@whig.com or mail them to Answers, The Quincy Herald-Whig, P.O. Box 909, Quincy, IL 62306. Please provide a name and phone number. Questions dealing with personal or legal disputes will not be accepted.

PERSPECTIVE

that’s
life...

Ruth Rems
Anna MacArthur



Anna MacArthur, left, and her mother, Ruth Rems, hold a document written by Anna’s father and Ruth’s late husband, Peter Rems, indicating the various cities across the United States he thought the family could settle in after enduring great hardship in the years after World War II in Germany. The family eventually settled in Lima.

Family that fled Russian army, communism tell tale of survival and undying love

Ruth Rems and her daughter Anna MacArthur sat Monday in the living room of Ruth’s Quincy home.

The year was 2008, but once the pair began talking, it was 1944 all over again.

That’s the year they fled their homeland of Latvia from the invading Russian army and the Soviet Union’s communist regime.

“I’ve gone over it, what our country was like when we left from communists,” Ruth said. “A long journey. My, my, my.”

Ruth’s husband, the late Peter Rems, was wanted for spreading anti-communist propaganda.

“My father had a horrendous life,” Anna recalled. “He was beaten and shot. Starved.”

The family fled across the countryside before ending up in Germany, where Peter was eventually captured.

“This didn’t happen in just a few weeks or months, Anna said. “It was two or three years. I was left with different people while my mother was trying to search for him.”

They eventually found each other, and timing played a remarkable part.

The family came to the U.S., settled in Lima and then moved to Quincy. Peter worked as a carpenter at Gardner Denver Co. He died June 10, 2007, at age 97.

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Ruth Rems and Anna MacArthur were interviewed and photographed in Rems’ Quincy home by Herald-Whig Photo Editor Philip Carlson

RR: WHEN WE LIVED IN LATVIA, THE RUSSIANS WERE very fast going, you know? The Germans fought them back, but they came again and again. Someone came to my husband from where he worked. They said, “Stay, or in two hours get ready to leave. Your choice.” So now everybody is packing. We have servants in our house. You opened the door, pigs and cows, chickens and (cattle). They all just looked like they feel something going on. And then you’re taking some (things), and you don’t know where you’re going. You just don’t know your future.

AM: WE WERE IN A COVERED WAGON, and we had a cow behind the wagon because I was young and I needed the milk. I remember that.

RR: SO THROUGH OUR STATE WE STARTED TRAVELING, and I remember that someplace we had to stop and stay overnight. And these people, the (Russian army) hadn’t reached them yet. They said: “What are you people doing here? What are you doing?” They didn’t want us to sleep in the barn overnight. We said: “You just wait. In a day or two, you’ll be doing the same thing.” Well, it didn’t take very long because we went from our state towards Riga (Latvia). Riga is the capital city, and we traveled through Riga to the Baltic Sea. 1944.

AM: WE WERE IN GERMANY FROM 1944 UNTIL 1950. Before we did all this moving, my father was in constant danger because he was anti-communist, and he was trying to tell the Latvian people not to go with the communists because the communists promise you everything. And what they did was just made a commune. They took away all the land from the wealthy, and everybody lived together in a commune and shared everything. And everybody worked. My dad, I never understood what was so important about him besides his big mouth, but they came to our house. They tried to burn the house down. And my dad had just built this house. It had a straw roof. And I remember the house being on fire. And I told Mom I remember, it must have been my great-grandmother or my grandmother, somebody that was blind, laying on a cot. And they just uplifted the cot. They were looking for my dad. And we would hide my dad in the wheat fields. The kitchen had a cellar underneath, and the trapdoor was under the kitchen table. And we hid my dad underneath that trapdoor and the kitchen table when the communists came looking for him and threatening all of us. It probably went on for two or three years. And then, like Mom said, they came and told him, “Either get out of here in two hours or you’ll be killed.” And that’s what happened to a lot of our relatives. They just picked them up, took them out to the woods and shot them.

RR: FROM THERE, WE DIDN’T SLEEP AT HOME. WE SLEPT IN FIELDS. Latvia is cold in May, June. One house, they took everything. The took all the food away, then they burned the family of six the same night. The whole family was burned. Parents and kids and all. Another (family), they put in a wagon, chained them all together with the parents, and drove them someplace to kill.

AM: THOSE WERE NEIGHBORS. And you must remember, back then, the communists ... anybody that had any brains, anybody that did their own thinking, they tried to destroy everything. All the intelligent people. Doctors, lawyers, they would take them into their (political) party and say, “Either do what we say or you’re going to die.” It’s like a scene in the movies, and you can’t fathom any of this because you’re too young to know what the heck went on after World War II.

FOR WHATEVER REASON, THEY PURSUED MY DAD, for whatever reason, the communists, even in Germany, were looking for my dad. He was captured by the Russians. We were hiding, and I remember what he told me. He was in some town, and of course, the building sections were all bombed. And he saw the Russians, and he went to hide in one of these buildings, and somebody in another building across the street saw him and said, “He’s over there, he’s over there.” Because back then it was you were against your brother, your father, your mother, anybody that you could, because it was give (the Russians) information or you die. And that’s how they got my dad the first time. And my dad escaped from an army transport truck, and that’s when he got shot and ended up in the hospital.

RR: THEY STARTED INVESTIGATING HIM AND SAID HE WAS A SPY, and here this Russian car comes to take him away. They didn’t know what to do. The American people, they got to him and translated. He said, “I left my family,” where he left us, you know? And then they pushed the Russians away and took Peter and put him in the hospital in the American zone. He was in the hospital in Linz, Austria. The nurse came to him one day, and said: “Mr. Rems, this is in the chart. When you get better we are supposed to give you to the Russians.” Peter, he didn’t sleep. The next day, the nurse said she would do something. Well, she got the chart, and she destroyed it. The doctor didn’t even see it. She destroyed his papers. When he got out, he didn’t know where I am now. No idea. He went into Munich, every office. No name, no name. Nothing.

I SAID: “WHAT AM I DOING HERE?” Germany is not my country. What do I do with these kids. No relations with me.” And I went to the Russian camp. They signed me in and welcomed me very, very good. They never asked whether I had a husband or whatever. And I signed (up) to go home. There was a lady downstairs, and I took my suitcase down there and put it in her closet. Then Peter was looking for us, and he found a woman who went to the Russian camp (to look for us). She went around (looking). I opened the door, and she was there, and she gave me a little piece of paper.

SHE GAVE ME THE PAPER, AND I READ IT. And Peter said: “I am over here. Can you get out and come to such and such place?” And I was already free. I had signed to go home, you know? Or Siberia, maybe. And I had a waiter to wait on me. And this waiter, he was very good to me. And he said: “Madam, what’s wrong with you? Is something wrong with you?” And I didn’t know whether I should tell him. So I said I am going to tell him my husband is here and looking for me. And he offered to help me. We were on the sixth floor, no elevator. I had already prepared the baby buggy with clothes for the baby. So I gave him the buggy, and here were all these Russian military, with the stars, all generals, going up (the stairs). And they said, “Madam, are you going for a walk?” And I said, “Yes, I am going for a walk.”

MY WALK WAS GOODBYE. I get the baby buggy around the corner, Peter was waiting someplace, a coffee shop, and we took a streetcar to some friends’ house. The (Russian officials) had told me, “The train is going tomorrow.” Monday. Back to Latvia. Or Siberia. And Peter found me Sunday. He found me at the last minute.